

Reassurance and Resistance: Racial Ideology in *Iron Man* and *Black Panther*

After 9/11, Hollywood's superheroes became ideological first responders. Their stories reassured audiences of Western strength, innocence, and moral clarity at a moment of national vulnerability. Yet not all superhero films offer the same fantasy. This paper analyzes *Iron Man* (2008) and *Black Panther* (2017). It shows how *Iron Man* reinforces the white racial frame by othering Arabs and centering white masculine power, while *Black Panther* explicitly challenges colonial narratives through Afrofuturist aesthetics and reversed gazes, yet also subtly reinforces aspects of colonial ideology, revealing the complexities of representing Black sovereignty within a Hollywood framework. This contrast is significant, revealing that the superhero genre can either reproduce or resist dominant racial ideologies. As Edwards and Esposito note, "films convey values, beliefs, and ideas that shape and reflect the cultures to which they belong" (Edwards and Esposito 124). This reminder makes clear that racial meanings in these films emerge not by accident but through deliberate cinematic choices, beginning with how each constructs authority on screen.

Iron Man frames white, masculine authority as natural and central, using key lighting, low angles, and a dark background that enhances his visual authority. In the interview scene (*Iron Man* 0:07:45 - 0:08:51), Tony's position at the absolute center of the power wheel as a wealthy, white, able-bodied male allows his unilateral military actions to be framed as heroic rather than aggressive. These choices operate within what Week 19 lecture defines as mise-en-scene (Wood, "Week 19" 35:52). His rhetoric reframes weapons manufacturing as "maintaining peace," legitimizing Western militarism. As Brown argues, post-9/11 superhero films often provide "a reassuring fantasy of America's ability to withstand terrorist attacks" (Brown 3). Brown's argument reveals that Stark's heroic framing is not neutral but part of a broader ideological project that reassures audiences of Western innocence and authority after 9/11. In the museum heist scene (*Black Panther* 0:15:33 - 0:17:05), Killmonger

confronts a white curator about stolen African artifacts. The scene begins with matched POV shots, then shifts to a low camera angle on Killmonger, visually asserting Black sovereignty as the curator's authority diminishes. This reverses the colonial gaze by exposing how Western institutions profit from African suffering. *Iron Man* positions white masculine authority as trustworthy, offering a reassuring fantasy for a post-9/11 audience. While *Black Panther*, exposes the violence of colonial extraction and reclaims Black cultural authority, challenging Hollywood's racial hierarchy. These distinctions matter because superhero films shape how millions imagine race, power, and global identity. The construction of white authority in *Iron Man* is further mirrored and complicated by the film's contrasting portrayal of Middle Eastern characters, which builds upon the patterns of legitimacy and authority established earlier.

Iron Man constructs Middle Eastern people as racialized threats, while *Black Panther* exposes white colonial violence. *Iron Man's* Ten Rings is introduced with low lighting, ominous music, and no subtitles (*Iron Man* 0:19:10 - 0:22:06), aligning with the "Terrorist" archetype (Wood, "Week 20", 34:44) and marking Middle Eastern characters as inherently threatening and irrational. Their shouted demands lack explanation, denying them the narrative space Tony receives to justify American militarism. This asymmetry frames US violence as rational and Arab resistance as irrational. In *Black Panther's* museum heist scene (*Black Panther* 0:15:33 - 0:19:23), Klaw is marked as villainous and colonial extractor through low camera angles and ominous music. His deception, cruelty, and theft expose colonial violence. *Iron Man's* film elements encourage viewers to see Middle Eastern characters as threats. Reinforcing the "Terrorist" archetype legitimizes Western fear and suspicion, resulting in wars being waged on the basis of such fear. *Black Panther* challenges this by exposing white violence and reclaiming Black historical agency, centering Klaw's theft and entitlement. The museum setting foregrounds white historical violence as the true threat. Yet *Black Panther* also reinforces the status quo symptomatically by isolating Klaw as a

lone-wolf criminal rather than a product of colonial systems. Displacing structural white violence onto a single deviant figure, leaving contemporary Western power unexamined. Together, these films show how the superhero genre can either perpetuate harmful racial myths or disrupt them by shifting who is allowed to be seen as dangerous, innocent, or powerful. This dynamic is not limited to characters; the landscapes and settings of each film also play a crucial role in constructing racial meaning.

Iron Man shows Afghanistan as barren and lifeless: Wide panning shots, dusty colors, and empty frames reinforce the single story of the Middle East as undeveloped and inhospitable (*Iron Man* 0:14:16 - 0:16:23). In contrast, Wakanda's reveal in *Black Panther* (*Black Panther* 0:12:34 - 0:13:55) rejects this "single story" of Africa (Wood, "Week 22" 33:40). Wide panning shots reveal lush green landscapes, vibrant colours, and a technologically advanced city that surpasses its Western counterparts. *Iron Man's* depiction of Afghanistan as empty and primitive implicitly justifies Western intervention by framing the region as lacking development and agency. The absence of civilians or cultural life reinforces the idea that the Middle East is defined solely by conflict, reproducing the dominant narrative of the region and its people. *Black Panther*, however, dismantles this colonial logic by presenting Africa as technologically brilliant and culturally sophisticated, challenging the hierarchy that positions Western nations as superior and forcing viewers to rethink Hollywood's portrayals of non-Western spaces. These ideological landscapes also inform how each film constructs ideals of masculinity.

In *Iron Man*, Tony's return to the US (*Iron Man* 0:41:20 - 0:42:47) shows white masculinity as stoic and emotionally contained. He hides his weakened state, lifting his chin as upbeat music plays. A low-angle shot emphasizes posture and control, signalling that vulnerability must be hidden once he returns to the public eye. In contrast, *Black Panther* presents Black masculinity as communal and emotionally honest. When T'Challa meets his father in the

ancestral plane (*Black Panther* 0:29:37 - 0:33:03), the front lighting, warm colour palette, and close-ups on his tearful face highlight his grief. He embraces his father, expresses uncertainty, and openly mourns. The soundtrack underscores his vulnerability, presenting emotional expression as a legitimate and even necessary part of leadership. These contrasting depictions reveal how each film ties masculinity to racial ideology. *Iron Man* reinforces a model of White masculine dominance in which strength is equated with emotional suppression and self-reliance. Tony's refusal of help and his forced bravado signal that vulnerability threatens his authority. *Black Panther*, however, rejects this racialized stoicism by redefining Black masculinity as communal, emotionally honest, and grounded in family ties. T'Challa's vulnerability does not diminish his power: it deepens it, challenging Hollywood's long-standing association of emotional expression with weakness. These films actively construct competing visions of what strength means within different racial frameworks, and this construction of masculinity intersects directly with the ways gender and racial power are depicted more broadly.

In *Iron Man*, the scene where Pepper removes Tony's arc-reactor wire (*Iron Man* 0:49:02 - 0:52:22) reinforces white patriarchal norms. The mysterious music, low-angle shots of Tony, and the lab setting frame him as the intellectual authority. Pepper repeatedly expresses uncertainty, yet Tony insists she proceed, and the camera captures her discomfort through close-ups and reaction shots. The scene positions Tony as the competent white male and Pepper as his uncertain assistant, reinforcing a gender hierarchy aligned with the white racial frame. *Black Panther*, through Dora Milaje's confrontation with Killmonger, centers Black women's authority and combat skills (*Black Panther* 01:43:56 - 01:47:39). Low-angle shots on Okoye and hype music flip the script on Black women's competence. Their disciplined movements and unwavering loyalty to Wakanda present Black womanhood as central to national power. As Claudia Bucciferro notes, Afrofuturist fiction "offers a space where new embodiments of Black womanhood can be explored" (Bucciferro 178), and this

scene embodies that possibility by rejecting the white patriarchal framing that marginalizes Black women. These contrasting depictions reveal how each film uses gender to articulate racial ideology. *Iron Man* reinforces a white patriarchal worldview in which women are positioned as assistants to male genius, their uncertainty used to justify male authority. *Black Panther*, however, redefines gendered power by placing Black women at the center of political, military, and technological life. Their leadership challenges Hollywood's marginalization of Black women and disrupts the racialized gender hierarchy. By reinforcing or challenging these intersections, films like *Iron Man* and *Black Panther* influence how audiences understand power, leadership and identity. Representation is not neutral. It actively constructs cultural narratives about whose bodies are deemed capable and worthy of respect, a dynamic powerfully reflected in how each film resolves its narrative and political commitments.

In *Iron Man*, Tony destroys his company's weapons by building a more powerful suit (*Iron Man* 01:28:34 - 01:30:13), reinforcing Western militarism as the only viable solution to global conflict. The scene's low-angle shots, amplified mechanical sounds, and his authoritative, adamant tone frame him as the sole figure capable of restoring order. In contrast, *Black Panther* resolves its racial politics through community-centered global engagement. When T'Challa visits Oakland with Shuri (*Black Panther* 02:00:48 - 02:02:53), the natural lighting, POV shots aligned with the children playing basketball, and the shift from low-angle shots on T'Challa to POV-level shots on Shuri create a tone of openness and relational leadership. Instead of asserting dominance, T'Challa proposes an outreach center that emphasizes education, cultural exchange, and Black solidarity. *Iron Man* reinforces a white racial frame in which technological superiority and militarized intervention are framed as necessary and inevitable. Teaching audiences to equate justice with militarized Western power, while *Black Panther* reimagines global responsibility through collective empowerment rather than domination. Yet the film also subtly reproduces elements of the colonial hierarchy it seeks to

challenge. The outreach center, for instance, frames Black liberation as achievable only through partnership with Western institutions. The same institutions are historically responsible for Black dispossession. As Edwards and Esposito caution that even celebratory representations exist within “the persistence of racism, capitalism, sexism, and the global domination of Western society” (Edwards and Esposito 125). Their point clarifies that *Black Panther’s* outreach center, while hopeful, still operates within the very power structures that the film critiques, revealing the limits of Hollywood’s ability to imagine liberation outside of Western frameworks. These films, therefore, offer competing visions of how racial power should operate, with *Iron Man* explicitly and *Black Panther* implicitly reinforcing aspects of the status quo. This complexity is further illuminated when considering the broader ideological work these films perform within the superhero genre as a whole.

A comparative analysis of *Iron Man* and *Black Panther* reveals how superhero films can either reinforce or resist dominant racial ideologies, sometimes within the same film. *Iron Man* centers white masculine authority and reaffirms a white racial, post-9/11 worldview. *Black Panther*, while explicitly challenging colonial narratives, imagines an African nation untouched by colonialism, technologically advanced, and communally led. Also subtly reinforces aspects of colonial logic, such as isolating white violence to a single villain rather than systemic forces. This complexity demonstrates that superhero narratives are not neutral; they shape ideas about who is dangerous, heroic and valued. Hollywood, as a leading cultural industry, both reflects and shapes social attitudes and beliefs. Recognizing this influence allows viewers to critically examine blockbuster films and the ways they construct, challenge, or subtly reinforce racial hierarchies. Understanding the ideological work of films like *Iron Man* and *Black Panther* is vital for interpreting media and the cultural forces shaping our worldviews.

Works Cited

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